The introduction of Buddhism in China had a great impact on Chinese society, but it was not all friendly and reverential. In his survey of China–India interactions from ancient times to 1939, Rudolf Wagner writes: 'The massive Chinese absorption . . . of basic Buddhist ideas and concepts, social institutions, and ritual practices was not to be accommodated within the existing system.'[5] Inevitably, there was resistance and repugnance in China. For one thing, Buddhism 'assigned it [China] a place as a "land at margin"'. India was the original (or co-equal) Madhyadesha or *Zhongguo* ('Middle Kingdom'). For China, this was difficult to accept. Buddhism, with its view of 'life as suffering', also went against 'a culture devoted to long life and prosperity'. China before Buddhism emphasized that young people should be 'productive, take care of their elders, and have children in order to continue the ancestor cult'. The new religion encouraged an existence marked by donations, a monastic life, and celibacy.[6] Chinese responses included creating a 'Buddhist narrative for China' or 'sidelining Buddhism' by older faiths and practices.[7] Daoism launched a strong attack, even arguing that its founder, Laozi, was the Buddha. In 842 CE, Emperor Wuzong declared Daoism as a true Chinese religion and 'proceeded to a systematic suppression and expropriation' of all 'foreign' religions. As the state came to control religion, Buddhism became a Chinese faith alongside Daoism and Confucianism.[8] That Buddhism had more or less collapsed in India by this time only helped in the Sinification of the religion: the land of its origin had ceased to be an inspiration.

India Looks Up to Imperial China

From here on, for seven hundred years from the ninth to the sixteenth century, it was trade, especially maritime trade, that came to mark India–China interchange: the material came to replace the spiritual. China's growing naval reach peaked in the voyages of Zheng He to Asia and Africa from 1405 to 1433, and parts of India became tributaries or felt the sharp end of Chinese power.